DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 9 | Lecture 1 | Unit III to Unit IV bridge

Strengths-Based Performance Management

Building on what people do best, and knowing when strengths become a liability

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Quiz 4

Quiz at the start of the session.
Select every option that applies. Closed book, closed phone.

Commit before theory

Your best analyst is brilliant with data but abrupt with clients. As her manager, where should development effort go?

A Fix the client skills; weaknesses hold careers back

B Build further on her analytic strength and route client work elsewhere

C Do both in equal measure

D It depends on whether the client weakness causes real harm in her role

The strengths premise

People grow most in the areas of their greatest talent, so development should start from strengths rather than from fixing weaknesses

Talent

Recurring patterns of thought, feeling and behavior

Strength

Talent refined by knowledge and skill into consistent performance

Manage weaknesses

Reduce their harm rather than trying to make them strengths

Two strengths traditions

Feature	Clifton and Gallup tradition	Character strengths tradition
Source	Buckingham and Clifton (2001)	Peterson and Seligman (2004)
Unit	Talent themes at work	Moral character strengths and virtues
Purpose	Performance and engagement at work	Wellbeing and good life
Root	Practitioner and consulting research	Positive psychology (Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi, 2000)

What the research supports

1 Strengths climate

van Woerkom and Meyers (2015): a strengths-based climate relates to positive affect and better performance

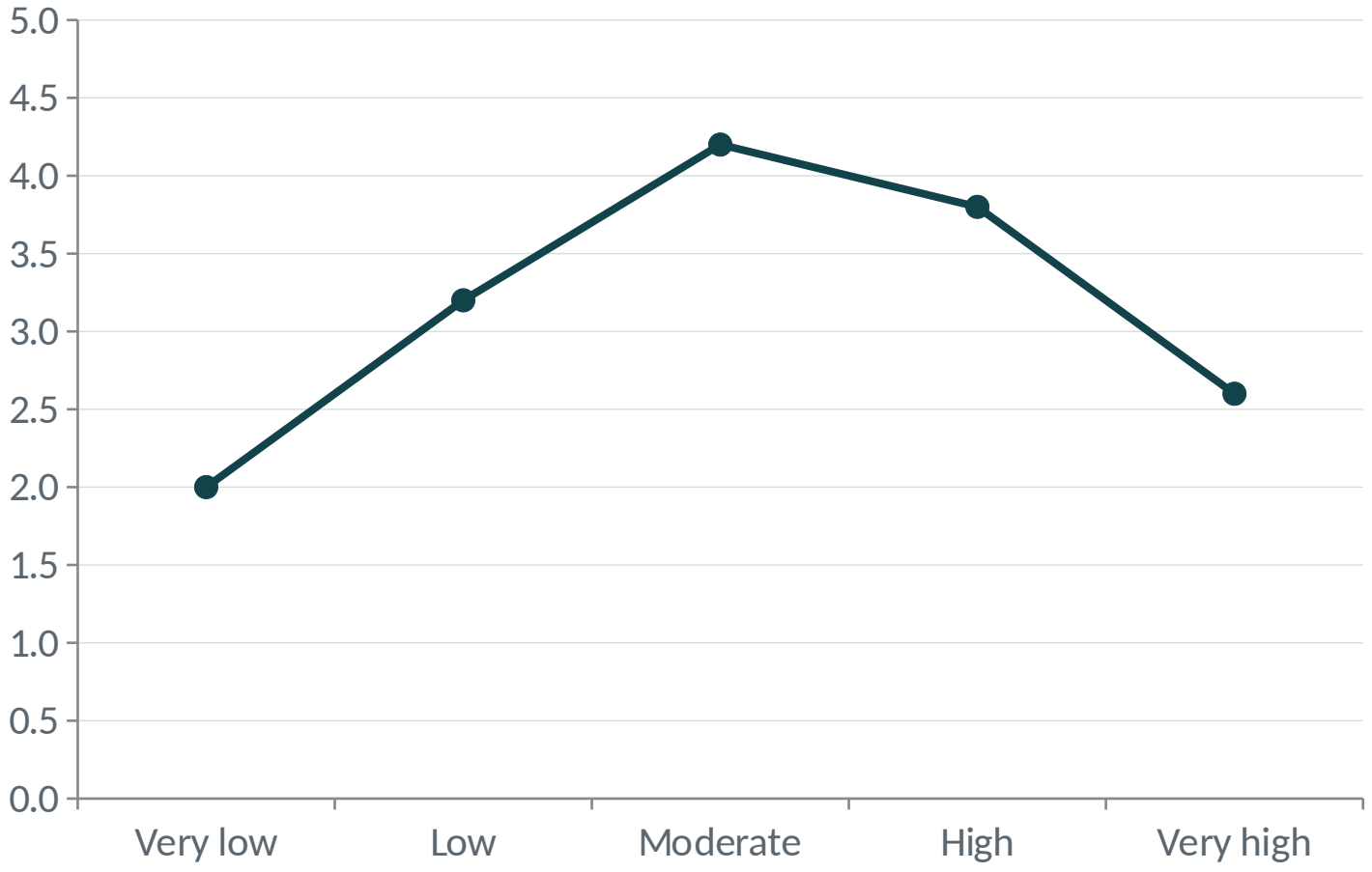
2 Strengths appraisal

Bouskila-Yam and Kluger (2011): strengths-based appraisal and feedforward can make reviews more constructive

3 Strengths feedback

Aguinis et al. (2012): feedback that builds on strengths is more likely to be accepted and used

Too much of a good thing



Illustrative numbers built for teaching, not real data

Grant and Schwartz (2011): many positive traits show an inverted U, where more is better only up to a point.

Kaiser and Overfield (2011): leaders often overuse strengths, producing lopsided leadership.

So strengths need calibration, not only amplification.

Feedback versus feedforward

Feedback

- Looks back at what went wrong
- Can shift attention to the self, not the task
- Kluger and DeNisi (1996): over a third of feedback interventions lowered performance

vs

Feedforward interview

- Asks about a time the person was at their best
- Identifies the conditions behind it
- Plans how to recreate them (Kluger and Nir, 2010)

Strengths at a regional bank

Teaching case (Course framing)

A cooperative bank in Gujarat adopts strengths profiles for all managers. Within a year, teams report more positive reviews, but some branch managers now refuse tasks outside their strengths, and two compliance lapses occur in branches where the manager scored low on detail and delegated nothing.

Work it through

1. Which parts of the strengths approach worked here?
2. Explain the lapses with Kaiser and Overfield
3. How should weaknesses be managed in roles with non-negotiable tasks?
4. Design a strengths-based review that still protects compliance

Exam-style question

Critically evaluate strengths-based performance management. Under what conditions should managers still address weaknesses? (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Defines talent and strength and separates the two traditions
- Cites supportive evidence such as van Woerkom and Meyers
- Uses Kaiser and Overfield and Grant and Schwartz for limits
- States clear conditions, such as critical tasks and overuse

Sources (1 of 2)

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Bouskila-Yam, O., & Kluger, A. N. (2011). Strength-based performance appraisal and goal setting. Human Resource Management Review, 21(2), 137-147. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2010.09.001

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Clifton, D. O., & Harter, J. K. (2003). Investing in strengths. In K. S. Cameron, J. E. Dutton, & R. E. Quinn (Eds.), Positive organizational scholarship (pp. 111-121). Berrett-Koehler.

Grant, A. M., & Schwartz, B. (2011). Too much of a good thing: The challenge and opportunity of the inverted U. Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6(1), 61-76. https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691610393523

Kaiser, R. B., & Overfield, D. V. (2011). Strengths, strengths overused, and lopsided leadership. Consulting Psychology Journal: Practice and Research, 63(2), 89-109. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0024470

Kluger, A. N., & DeNisi, A. (1996). The effects of feedback interventions on performance. Psychological Bulletin, 119(2), 254-284. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254

Kluger, A. N., & Nir, D. (2010). The feedforward interview. Human Resource Management Review, 20(3), 235-246. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2009.08.002

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van Woerkom, M., & Meyers, M. C. (2015). My strengths count! Human Resource Management, 54(1), 81-103. https://doi.org/10.1002/hrm.21623